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Lucian Leape

Paediatric surgeon and champion of patient safety. Born on Nov 7, 1930, in Bellevue, PA, USA, he died of heart failure on June 30, 2025, in Lexington, MA, USA, aged 94 years.

Lucian Leape contributed to two advances in medicine: after pioneering work in paediatric surgery, he became an influential champion of patient safety. "He was a brilliant paediatric surgeon and then his career just shifted dramatically", said Patricia McGaffigan, Senior Advisor for Patient and Workforce Safety at the Institute for Healthcare Improvement (IHI) in Boston, MA, USA. Drawn to improving patient safety partly by some of the medical errors he had seen during his career as a surgeon, Leape "became the conscience of the modern patient safety movement", McGaffigan said. "He gave voice to the ethical commitments and obligations that we have to ensure that we are bringing forward every opportunity possible to make care safer for all."

Leape studied chemistry at Cornell University in Ithaca, NY, graduating in 1952. After serving in the US Navy, he studied at Harvard Medical School in Boston, MA, graduating in 1959, and then completed trainings in general and thoracic surgery at Massachusetts General Hospital and in the emerging field of paediatric surgery at Boston Children's Hospital. "It was very exciting", he said in a 2006 interview. "We were pioneering and developing a new specialty." In 1970 he helped found the American Pediatric Surgical Association and 3 years later became Professor of Surgery at Tufts University School of Medicine in Boston and Chief of Pediatric Surgery at what is now the Tufts Medical Center in Boston, MA. There came a "moment when I decided I was going to leave surgery", Leape recalled in the interview. "I had done the usual academic things, and I was wondering what I was going to do for the next 20 years. I was always interested in how to change things and make the world a better place."

In 1986, Leape took a mid-career fellowship at the RAND Corporation to study epidemiology, statistics, and health policy, before joining what is now the Harvard T H Chan School of Public Health as an Adjunct Professor in the Department of Health Policy and Management. He became part of a team working on the Harvard Medical Practice Study, reviewing thousands of hospitalised cases to estimate the incidence of injuries from medical mismanagement and negligent or substandard care. In a 2006 interview, Leape said "the surprise for me" was not that nearly 4% of patients had adverse events, but that "two thirds of them were caused by errors". This research contributed to the publication of the landmark 1999 report, *To Err Is Human: Building a Safer Health System*, by what was then the Institute of Medicine's Committee on Quality of Health Care in America, of which Leape was a member. Drawing on this research, Leape also wrote a seminal paper, *Error in Medicine*, in the *Journal of the American Medical Association* in 1994. "What he did was pretty radical. He was really swimming upstream on many fronts", said Gordon Schiff, Professor of Medicine at Harvard Medical School. "No one wanted to hear that health care was not safe and that harm was something that we could prevent and had an ethical duty to prevent", McGaffigan said. Leape emphasised, though, "that we have to stop blaming individuals and look at systemic factors", said Paula Griswold, Executive Director of the Massachusetts Coalition for the Prevention of Medical Errors in Burlington, MA.

Leape continued to lead the evolution of the patient safety movement. "Over time, he kept moving forward, honestly talking with patients and families. Supporting them and supporting clinicians after harm occurs", Griswold said. "He emphasised how crucial it is for leaders to remain visibly committed to safety—workforce safety, as well as patient safety." Leape helped to create the National Patient Safety Foundation in 1997; a decade later the organisation established the Lucian Leape Institute as a patient safety think tank. It is now part of IHI. Among his many awards, he received the American Pediatric Surgical Association's Distinguished Service Award in 2004. In 2021, Leape's book *Making Healthcare Safe: The Story of the Patient Safety Movement* was published.

Leape's wife, Martha, died earlier this year. He is survived by their three sons, James, Jonathan, and Gerald, and seven grandchildren. "He could see the gaps in health-care quality in a way nobody else could", said Maureen Bisognano, President Emerita and Senior Fellow at IHI. "He was relentless. He would never stop pushing on the changes we need to make."

Andrew Green